

Feel-Good Design Cheatsheets

June 2024 / ver. 3.0

The Moments Framework is the most essential, new strategic element in our Brand Identity. It demonstrates how our design tools are used across all moments. It ranges from Day-to-Day Moments, over Brand Moments, to Partnership Moments.

Important note: These Cheatsheets are focussed on Day-to-Day Moments. For complete details on the Moments Framework, visit <https://me.mcd.com/design>.

70% Day-to-Day Moments

Adding dimension & dynamism

Sustaining: Core, Core Packaging, POP, Daily App Deals, LTO's, Always-on, Corporate communication, etc.



15% Brand Moments

Dressing up for the occasion

Occasions: Grimace's Birthday, Big Mac Anniversary, Camp McDonald's, Deals stuck in Time, etc.

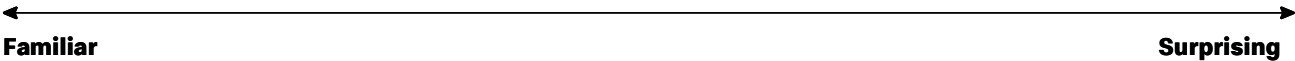


15% Partnership Moments

Sharing the pen

Share the pen: Famous Orders, CPFM Meal, Verdy, etc.





*Visit <https://me.mcd.com/design> for additional guidance, case studies, tools, downloadable assets and complete details on the Moments Framework.

Day-to-Day Moments are the most common occurrences of the brand and play a pivotal role in building memory structures with our Fans. These Moments stand for the majority of interactions with our brand; they can still be surprising, but are closer to our core identity. Though they are closer to the core of the brand, new techniques can add fresh dimension and dynamism.



Our brand promise is at the heart of everything we do.

Making Delicious, Feel-Good Moments Easy for Everyone.

Overview

Key distinctive assets that will be covered in the Masterbrand Cheatsheets:

- The Golden Arches
- Sonic Identity
- Color
- Typography
- Food Photography
- Lifestyle Photography
- Illustrations

Fan Truths

We believe there is a McDonald’s Fan in everyone.

So everything we do is rooted in how our Fans interact with the brand. There’s huge power in the small truths our audience already knows: the moments, memories, rituals, behaviors that make this brand so special.

We call these Fan Truths, and they are at the heart of our brand. There are hundreds of Fan Truths just waiting to be told.

What makes a Fan Truth



Specific

Fan Truths aren’t super general, instead they describe something a little more particular and small.



Shared

Fan Truths are always relatable and authentic. However, sometimes Fan Truths will be universally relatable and sometimes Fan Truths will apply to a niche sub-group.



Special

Fan Truths should make people feel better about McDonald’s. There’s room for some self-deprecation and real honesty too, so long as it’s charming. It doesn’t need to present McDonald’s as perfect. If it’s authentic and makes people smile with us, then it’s a great Fan Truth.

new

Voice

Fan-to-Fan

Speak like you are one Fan speaking to another

(And not like a corporation speaking down to its customers)

Tone of Voice

It is critical that this voice is consistent throughout all of our channels. From social, through to retail and campaigns.

Authentic

Thoughtful

Witty

Optimistic

new

Personality

Our personality defines how our brand shows up in the world.

Lighthearted

Welcoming

Dependable

Unpretentious

Playful

new

Our creative principles guide our thinking and approach.

Confidently humble

Continue to express the bold, **simple essence** of McDonald’s. If it doesn’t add, take it away. Negative space is a positive. We don’t follow category norms; instead, we define them.

Familiar yet surprising

Lean more into the future nostalgia that Gen Z yearns for, while also building new, modern, globally relevant memory structures. Continue to find ways of adding a **playful wink** that surprises and delights.

Flawesome

Be flawsome and celebrate **simple moments and imperfections** that speak on a personal rather than corporate level. Play with context, scale, contrast, balance, movement and energy.

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Golden Arches

We all know the feeling of the Golden Arches. They are so much more than a logo, they are our brand beacon, an iconic asset and equity, and the inspiration for our Brand Identity.



Day-to-Day Moments with the Golden Arches

We use our Golden Arches for everyday, functional communications and in straightforward, yet inspiring ways. Where the message needs to be more bold or resonate specific messages, some liberties can be taken, but we always start with the core Golden Arches: key word being “Golden.” And remember to always follow the Three Golden Rules (see next page).



Do		Do Not	
Golden Arches in McDonald's Gold	Token used for improved visibility over complicated background	Golden Arches in color other than McDonald's Gold	Golden Arches difficult to see over complicated background

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Three Golden Rules

Keep these three rules in mind to ensure our Golden Arches stay iconic and unmistakable.

Note: The Three Golden Rules apply to all three types of Moments.

When referring to our brand icon in copy, we always say “the Golden Arches”, not just the “Arches”. The “Golden” is part of the brand icon name and is why we don’t allow it to appear in other colors.



- 1 Always features the distinctive curves & taper
- 2 Always in McDonald’s Gold
- 3 The outside stems are longer than the middle/inside stem

Clearspace

				2X
2X	X			

Print 4 mm
Digital 15 px



Clearspace is equal to the width of one leg of the Golden Arches.

Note: The Golden Arches do not require ® or ™, except within our corporate website and similar applications.



Do not violate clear space rules.



Do not use the Golden Arches too close to type, without proper clearspace.

Approval process

Please follow the below approval process: For the purpose of ensuring compliance and protecting the Golden Arches logo, you must gain Global Brand Marketing and Global Marketing/IP legal approval when treating the Golden Arches. Approval is required at concept stage, and for close-to-final assets.

See detailed approval process here:
<https://me.mcd.com/guidelines/masterbrand/the-golden-arches>



Cropping



Staging



Motion



Perspective



Repetition



Dimensional

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Watchouts



Do not use colors other than Gold for the Golden Arches.



Do not use use on backgrounds that compromise the legibility of the Golden Arches.



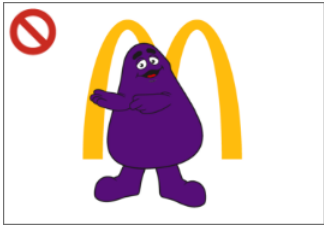
Do not apply drop shadows to the Golden Arches.



Do not use the Golden Arches as letters or numbers.



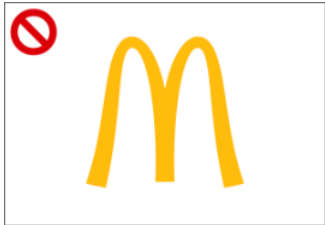
Do not rotate the Golden Arches



Do not cover the Golden Arches.



Do not use the Golden Arches as a mask for images or textures.



Do not warp or stretch the Golden Arches (including in motion and animation).



Do not treat the Golden Arches beyond recognition.



Do not use animated or bouncing Golden Arches for still uses. They are reserved for animation.

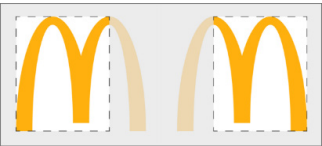


Do not flip the Golden Arches.

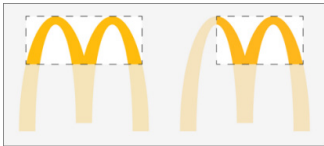


Do not use a dated version of the modern Golden Arches.

Cropping allowed for Day-to-Day Moments



Four cropped sets of the Golden Arches are [available for download](#).



Use the provided artwork to ensure consistency and maintain the integrity of the Golden



Do not change the provided artwork for the cropped Golden Arches.



Do not crop treated Golden Arches in Brand or Partnership Moments.



When the Golden Arches are less obvious because of extreme cropping, reinforce the brand by using the Golden Arches mark or the Token. Required on out-of-home activations only.

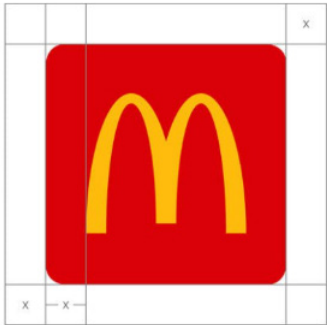


Exception: Alternative crops may be used in photography. However, artwork must be approved by the Global Brand team.

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The Token

We use the stand alone Golden Arches wherever possible. In instances where scale, legibility and contrast pose challenges, use the Token as a stand in for our iconic Golden Arches.

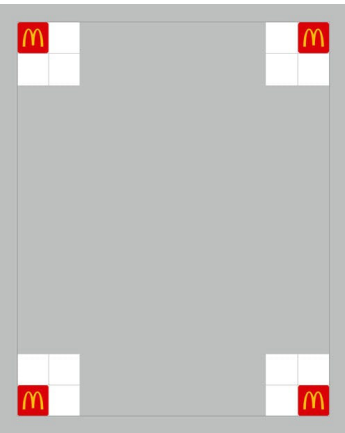


Clearspace is equal to the distance between the leg of the Golden Arches and the edge of the Token.



The European Green Token is available for use in European Green markets only.

Scale and placement



Place the Token in one of the corners of a layout.

The exact corner placement and positioning within the quadrants are flexible, as indicated here. The preferred placements are bottom left or top right.

Minimum height
Print 6 mm
Digital 25 px

Note: The Token no longer requires ® or ™, except within our corporate website and similar applications.

Scale and placement of the Token are flexible depending on context. Legibility of the Token ensures that our brand is immediately identifiable.



Best practices

Use the Token in places where greater contrast and visual impact are needed.



Just right

The Token provides contrast against the background image.



No contrast

The Golden Arches are difficult to see against the background image.



Just right

The Token supports the Golden Arches and provides contrast.



No contrast

At small scale the Golden Arches get lost on white backgrounds.

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Sonic Identity

Beyond our visual world, how we sound is just as important in the worlds that we look to build. The five-note is one of our most overlooked equities, while being one of the most impactful. Its primary purpose is to serve as a moment of brand recognition at the end of work, but it can be brought to life in creative ways. Because it’s so iconic and recognizable, it gives us the freedom to reimagine it for the worlds we create. What it’s important is to make sure it maintains some connection to the original.

Five-Note

This is our evergreen sonic asset.
The visual and audio in this Day- to-Day asset should not be changed.



In Day-to-Day Moments, we make sure to use our Sonic Identity in its pure form where it feels the most applicable. It can be used in both visual and audio ways:

Visual: Lean into our iconic assets to create unmistakable expressions of our sonic identity for Day-to-Day Moments.

Audio: The mnemonic serves as an audio cue and sign-off to build brand recognition with our Fans.



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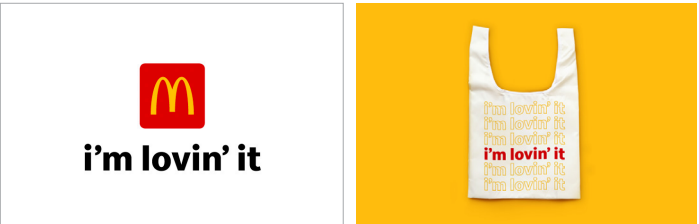
Tagline

Our tagline is a powerful asset—it’s instantly recognizable, warm and filled with meaning to our Fans. It’s almost as recognizable as our Golden Arches, which is a pretty big deal. In fact, according to a recent WARC study, a brand’s tagline is the second-most powerful asset to drive brand growth. We still need to make sure to use it with purpose, as overuse will diminish its meaning.



Day-to-Day Moments with the Tagline

A custom piece of artwork set in Speedee, it is most found capping a meaningful experience: whether it be an end tag on a commercial or on our packaging. Since it is punctuating other content and experiences, it doesn’t need to be rendered or treated in any special way. It shows up here just as its joyful, iconic self.



Do

Use provided artwork locked up with the Token

Use provided artwork

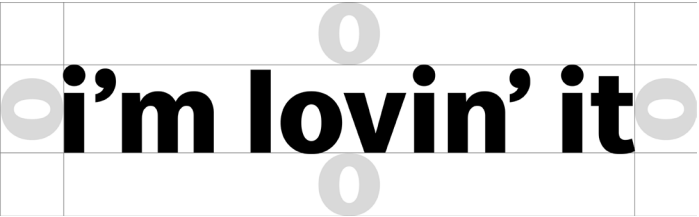
Do Not

Provided artwork has not been used

Artwork has been treated

Details for Day-to-Day Moments

Make sure our tagline is used with purpose. Overuse will diminish its meaning. Showin’ it can be more powerful than sayin’ it.



Clearspace is equal to the height of the “o” of the word “lovin.”

Minimum height

Print 3 mm
Digital 8 px



Note: We want to encourage you to use “i’m lovin’ it” (or an approved local translation, if applicable for your market) for your TVC/OLV end cards, as shown here. The Tagline must sit centered below the Token. Please consult with your local Legal counsel which Tagline version is approved for your market.

Do

Tagline size is in correct relationship scale to Token

Do Not

Tagline size is too large in relationship scale to Token

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Wordmark

The Golden Arches welcomes Fans from afar, and our Wordmark greets Fans at the door. The custom set of type is an iconic secondary mark.



Day-to-Day Moments with the Wordmark

Everyone knows our name — we don't always have to say it. Though it looks a bit like Speedee, note that this is a custom wordmark.



Our Wordmark is mostly reserved for horizontal restaurant fascias and corporate applications.

Do

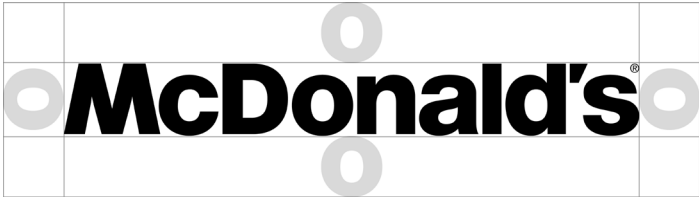
Use our word mark on exterior fascias as a globally recognizable signifier of our brand.

Do Not

In both of these examples, our brand is already clearly identified by the Golden Arches so there is no need for the Wordmark.

Details for Day-to-Day Moments

Make sure our tagline is used with purpose. Overuse will diminish its meaning. Showin' it can be more powerful than sayin' it.



Clearspace is equal to the height of the "o" of the McDonald's Wordmark.

Minimum height

Print 3 mm
Digital 8 px

McDonald's



Color

The Wordmark is only ever used in black or white.

Watchout for Day-to-Day Moments



Do not lock the Wordmark up with the Golden Arches.

Do not treat the Wordmark in any way.

Do not type out the Wordmark in other fonts, including Speedee.

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Color

Our brand is Golden: a color that captures a sense of authenticity and warmth that comes with not only eating at a McDonald’s, but interacting with our brand as a whole.

Our palette is bold, simple and unmistakable. In Day-to-Day Moments, we focus primarily on our iconic core colors—Gold, Red and White to build familiarity. But, it’s not just the hues that are special: it’s also the proportions. Allowing for negative space reinforces our joyful simplicity. When the occasion calls for it, we can also use product-inspired colors.



Do

Leads with gold as the brand color.

Secondary hues supporting a product story.

Do Not

McDonald's completely disappears.

Use background colors that are not associated with our brand.

Brand palette

McDonald's Gold
PMS
Coated 1235 C
Uncoated 122 U
CMYK 0.29.96.0
RGB 255.188.13
HEX FFBC0D

Inspired by melted cheese and crispy fries, our McDonald's Gold is tasty, cheerful and bright.

McDonald's Red
PMS 2035 C
CMYK 0.100.95.0
RGB 219.0.7
HEX DB0007

Our use of Red is akin to our iconic fries dipped in ketchup. With our Red, a little goes a long way.

McDonald's European Green
PMS 350 C
CMYK 66.0.72.70
RGB 38.79.54
HEX 264F36

European Green is only available for use in existing European Green markets, the Token, and existing activations such as restaurant facias.

Functional palette - limited use

Black CMYK 0.0.0.100 RGB 0.0.0 HEX 000000	Charcoal PMS Cool Gray 11 C CMYK 0.0.0.80 RGB 45.45.45 HEX 2D2D2D	Light Gray PMS Cool Gray 1 C CMYK 0.0.0.8 RGB 247.247.247 HEX F7F7F7	Kraft PMS 2312 C CMYK 25.37.50.04 RGB 182.154.129 HEX B69A81
Black is only used for type.	Charcoal, light gray and kraft are reserved for use on internal communications and for some illustrative elements.		

Using Product IP colors in Day-to-Day Moments

In Day-to-Day Moments, we can introduce Product IP colors when spotlighting a specific product.

Big Mac

McMuffin

McFlurry

Watchouts

Do not use Product IP colors in a way that leaves the product being featured ambiguous or unrecognizable. See the examples below for watchouts.

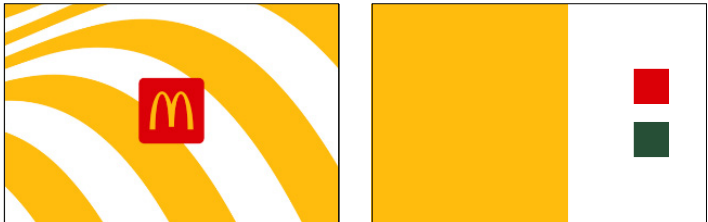
Do not use the wrong colors or too much of just one color.

Do not mix colors from different products together.

Do not introduce colors that are not associated with a product or the brand.

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Usage and Proportions



Primary color proportion

While Gold is our primary brand color, it's the combination and proportion of our colors that makes us unmistakable and visually distinctive.

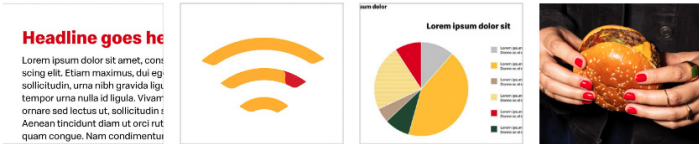
Although we are a Golden brand, Red plays an important role. Be sure to include an accent of Red in the Brand experience.

Accent color usage depends on your region. Some markets in Europe use European Green, whereas the rest of the markets use Red.

Not every single application will have the same balance of color. The overall color proportion of our brand includes plenty of breathing room with lots of Gold, and splashes of Red or (European Green) accents.

Accent colors

Accents of Red (or European Green) can be added through various techniques.



Typography

Illustrative details

Infographics

Photography



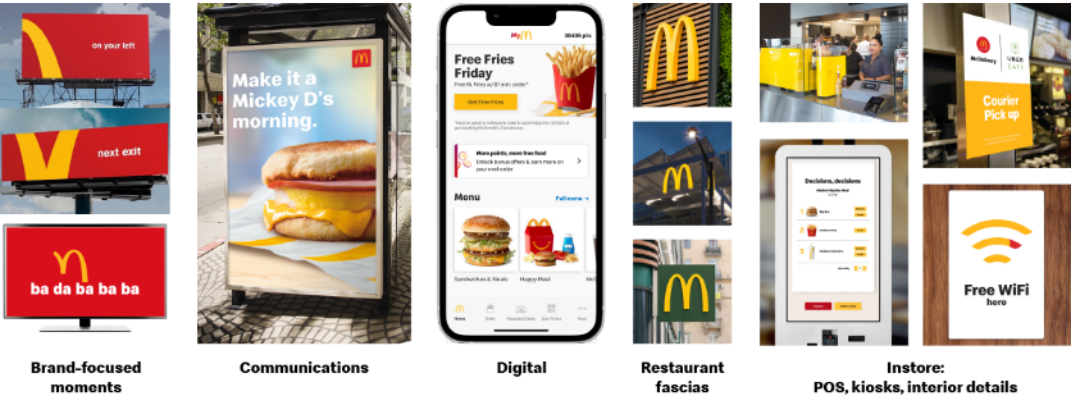
Propping

Imagery

Merch

Length of consumer engagement

The length of consumer engagement informs our overall approach to color



Blink and you'll miss it

2-3 second engagement
Brand volume 10
Product volume 1

At a glance

1-2 minute engagement
Brand volume 5
Product volume 5

Stay a while

2 minutes + engagement
Brand volume 1
Product volume 10

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Typography

One global font. One global voice.
Inspired by the Golden Arches, our
brand font Speedee adds a touch of
personality to everything we say.

Speedee Bold
Speedee Regular
Speedee Light

1234567890
\$£€&#%.,:’!?

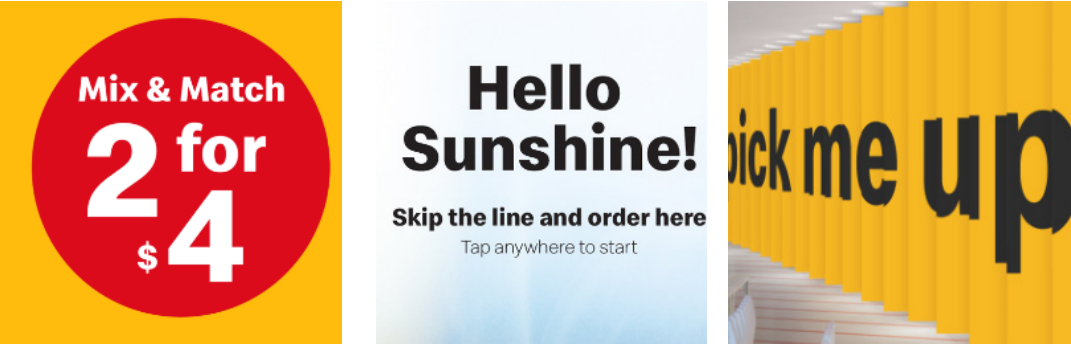
Speedee Condensed Bold
Speedee Condensed Regular
Speedee Condensed Light

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Use of Speedee

We always use Speedee for everyday, functional communications and in straightforward and clear ways. In instances where the message needs to be more bold or resonate specific messages, some liberties can be taken to add dimension to the type, but we always start with Speedee.

Core use of Speedee



Illustrative use of Speedee



Typesetting

Keep headlines
short and sweet.

Speedee Regular and Light are perfect for body copy and other applications where we’re conveying lots of information at once.

Speedee Regular is great for subheads.
Use Speedee Bold for emphasis.

Though Speedee Bold is highly legible, it can be difficult to read in large amounts. Use Bold in body copy only for **emphasis**.

Limited use

Italics are used for Latin words, movie titles (.e.g, in Happy Meal partnerships), etc.

Speedee Condensed is only for functional purposes such as legal.

Line spacing

This leading is much too tight.

The leading is just right.

This leading is too spaced out.

Comfortable line spacing is important for legibility and consistency.

Highlighting

On internal communications, McDonald’s Gold can be used as a highlight color to create hierarchy and add emphasis.

Print application

Black, Red or Gold type on white	Black, white or Red type on Gold	White or Gold type on Red
Black or Red type on light photography	White or Gold type on dark photography	 DO NOT use Gold or Red in body copy

Digital application

Black or Red type on white	Black type on Gold	White type on Red
Black or Red type on light photography	White type on dark photography	 DO NOT use Gold or Red in body copy
 Avoid Gold type on white in digital contexts	 Avoid Red and white type on Gold in digital contexts	 Avoid Gold type on Red in digital contexts

Food Photography

The gooey melt of the cheese, crispy crunch of a fry, the crinkle of a wrapper. We don’t just depict how our iconic products look: we shoot them in a way that makes you remember all their delicious, Flawesome details.



Closeups
Is your mouth watering yet? Macro shots capture all those delicious details.



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Day-to-Day Moments with Food Photography

Each iconic product has its own memorable characteristics, but we shoot everything with a cohesive sense of place and authenticity. The guidance showcases our photography style, so that our products are cohesive, craveable and instantly recognizable.



Do		Do Not	
Slightly irregular stack of ingredients are lit in a way that captures a lot of detail and dimension. Even when on a white background, a shadow grounds it on a surface.	Blurred out, naturally-lit environments and imperfectly wrinkled paper create a relatable sense of place while keeping the image simple.	Product is too symmetrical and polished, diminishing authenticity and taste appeal. Shadow doesn't feel authentic.	Lighting is too flat, causing the product to look flat and lose a lot of delicious detail. Perfect Serve wrapper is missing.

Let’s dig in a bit more into what makes it “Flawesome”
Flawesome is one of our visual identity principles. It’s all about celebrating the simple moments and charming imperfections that makes our food real.



Moments of realism, like when the cheese touches the wrapper. Organic, natural drips

Lighting and shadows

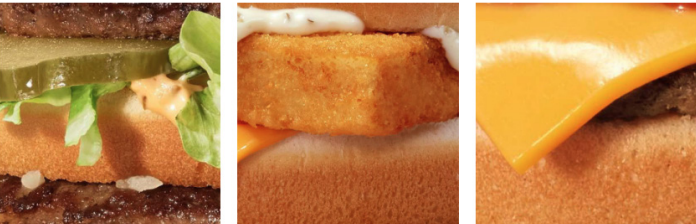
Even the most delicious sandwich can look unappealing if shot in the wrong light. In this section we go over best lighting practices and how to create a warm, natural environment for our products so they can shine.



The appearance of natural lighting suggests a warm, inviting and real environment.

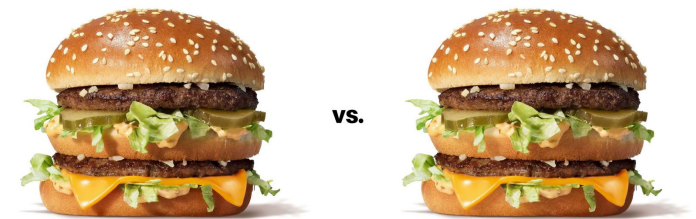
Single light source The more natural, the better	Real-life shadows Captured in-camera, not added in post

Ingredient shadows are the shadows ingredients cast onto other ingredients in the sandwich.



Pickle casting shadow on lettuce. Lettuce casting shadow on bun and onions. Filet casting shadow on bun and cheese. Cheese casting shadow on patty and bun.

Ingredient shadows bring depth and realism in our products



Prominent ingredient shadows
+ Tactile
+ Cheese and sauce look robust and real
Lacks ingredient shadows
x Flatter image overall
x Ingredients and bun blend together

Environment

When creating environments for our menu items, we want to ensure that we use authentic materials, surfaces, and backgrounds that accurately reflect the dining experience.

They should feature tones of Gold that add richness, depth and deliciousness to our photographs, and should use depth of field to hero the product.

Light background option	Dark background option

Backgrounds are intended to be cropped into for maximum impact.



The food should always be the focus of the shot.



x Background drawing focus + Food is the focus

Lifestyle Photography

new

Just like our Flawsome product shots, our lifestyle imagery captures the real and relatable in-the-moment details of a true Fan. Lifestyle photography should always be Real, Relatable and Together.



Our food isn't meant to be perfect, and neither are we.

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Lifestyle Photography

new

Here, we focus on the shared daily moments with our iconic products and experiences that everyone can relate to.



Do

Candid, in-the-moment scene centered around our products.

Do Not

Overly staged and unnaturally posed.

Usage and guidance

new

Our imagery speaks Fan-to-Fan, highlighting those special relatable moments. Never posed or overly polished, we build on the Flawesomeness of product imagery by capturing the in-between moments and all their fun imperfections. Food is community. Even if we are capturing an individual, the way we capture a scene invites the viewer in as if they are there as well.



Always real
We capture imperfections that make things feel real, rather than perfectly polished. When used



Always relatable
We capture our Fans as the truest and most authentic versions of themselves. When we see a Fan, we



Always together
Celebrate spontaneous, authentic moments that bring us together.

The Perfect Serve

We use idealized physical versions of our product packaging in our communications for more impact and differentiation.



Day-to-Day Moments with Perfect Serve

Simple, joyful, and unmistakably McDonald's. The Perfect Serve is featured in iconic moments with food and people.



Do		Do Not	
			
Using our Perfect Serve artwork ensures our products look their best and are instantly recognizable.		Uses the Simply Delicious Design packaging instead of Perfect Serve	Uses promotional packaging instead of Perfect Serve

Examples

The “Perfect Serve” refers to the idealized versions of our packaging featured in marketing and advertising communications. We use this to ensure consistent results and a unified recognizable brand.



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Illustrations need to be flexible, yet ownable and cohesive. Usage depends on context, and can range from functional to expressive.

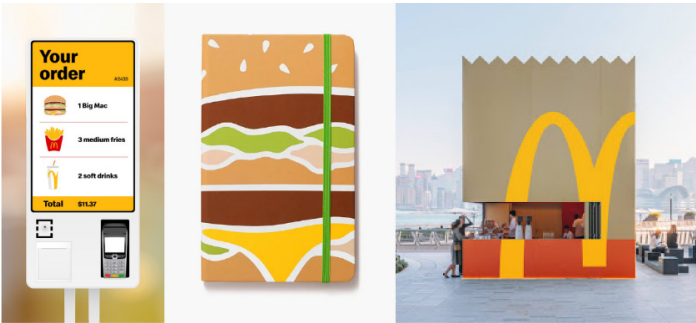
Product icons

Product icons depict our classic products in a graphic, joyful manner and help aid in navigation.



Product icons in use

Product Icons are useful in small digital spaces. They can also be brought to life in delightful ways in animation, merchandise and 3D environments.

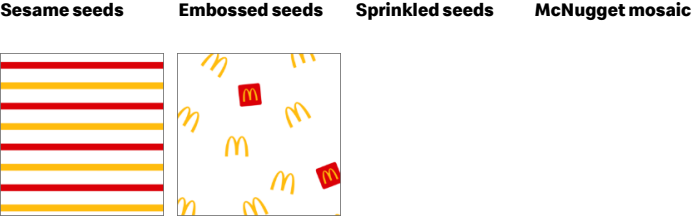
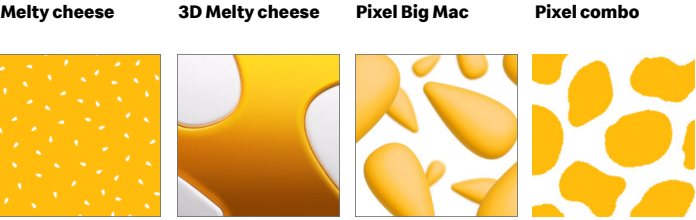
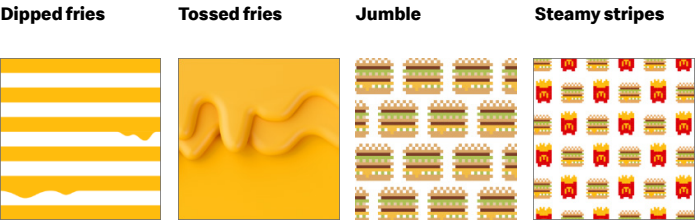


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Playful Patterns

new

Playful patterns have been recently updated to include a variety of dimensional options and help to give a joyful feeling.



Playful Patterns in use



Feel-Good Illustration Style

new

Our illustration style is positive, playful and distinctive—capturing Feel-Good moments inspired by our brand.

The approach to these illustrations isn't limited to a single style or illustrator. Rather, we are grounded by a set of principles that provides the creative opportunity to develop illustrated libraries locally, while maintaining global cohesiveness.

Our Feel-Good Illustration Style is made distinctive through 4 main principals and approaches:

1. Creative Principles

Our Principles guide our thinking and approach to illustration.

Confidently humble

Simple compositions work best to create focus.

Always unmistakably McDonalds. Capture the essence of our brand by leaning into what makes us unique.

Familiar yet surprising

Playful scale and perspective

Surprise and delight. Variation within our established Feel-Good Illustration Style will bring depth and dimension to the brand.

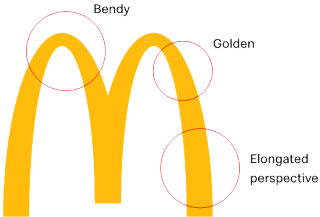
Flawesome

Celebrate Fan Truths. Capture real, relatable moments and rituals.

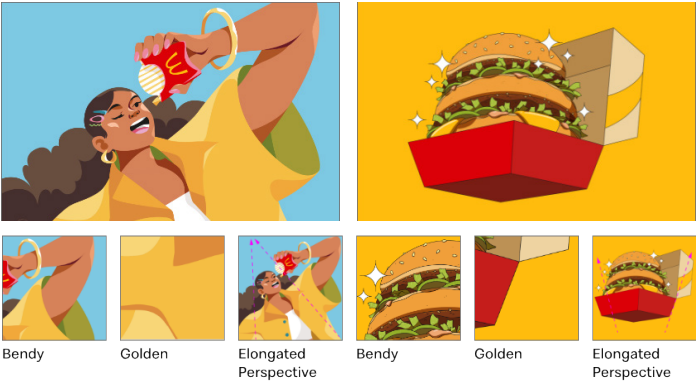
Lean into Archery as inspiration to play with context, scale, contrast, balance, movement and energy.

2. Inspiration

Aspects of the Golden Arches have inspired our Feel-Good Illustration approach.



Below are examples of Inspiration applied to the Feel-Good Illustrations.



3. Fan Truths

Our Feel-Good Illustration Style is rooted in Fan Truths—capturing real, relatable moments that are authentic and unique to our brand.



Ordering at the drive-thru with a car full of people will always descend into chaos.

Your friend will always take a fry, even if they said they didn't want any.

POV of opening a clamshell to see your Big Mac.

4. Illustration color palette

Our Feel-Good Illustrations contain a prominent use of Gold and focused hits of White and Red to ensure our illustrations are recognizably McDonald's.

To create balance and variety, we can lean into our wider palette of colors from our Simply Delicious Packaging design. Tints and shades can be added to bring depth and dimension.

Our illustrations are inclusive and show a range of skin tones and people of various ages.



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